

Hackathon Guide - January 2026

Best Active Hackathons

1. AI Vibe Coding Hackathon (TOP PICK)

- **Prize Pool:** \$180,359 total
- **First Place:** \$1,000
- **Dates:** January 30 – February 2, 2026
- **Format:** Online
- **URL:** <https://vibe.devpost.com/>

Requirements: - Team: Up to 4 members - Video: Max 3 minutes - Code: Public GitHub repo with setup instructions - Optional: Slides and demo link

Judging Criteria: - Technical Execution: 40% - Innovation/Wow Factor: 30% - Potential Impact: 20% - Presentation/Demo: 10%

Pro Tips: - Open-source projects get bonus prizes - AI integration preferred but not mandatory - Build anything: game, tool, analyzer, controller

2. Next Byte Hacks: January 2026

- **Prize Pool:** \$100+ cash + CodeCrafters VIP
 - **1st Place:** \$50 + 2-year VIP (\$720 value)
 - **Deadline:** February 15, 2026
 - **Eligibility:** Students only, ages 13+
 - **URL:** <https://next-byte-january-2026.devpost.com/>
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3. DeveloperWeek 2026 Hackathon

- **Prize Pool:** Sponsor prizes (varies)
 - **Format:** In-person + Online
 - **URL:** <https://developerweek-2026-hackathon.devpost.com/>
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How Hackathons Work

Typical Flow

1. **Register** on Devpost before deadline
2. **Build** your project during the event window
3. **Submit** before deadline with:
 - Project description
 - Demo video (1-3 min)
 - GitHub repo link
 - Screenshots
4. **Wait** for judging
5. **Win** prizes if selected

What Makes a Winning Project

- **Completeness:** Working demo > ambitious broken prototype
- **Polish:** Good UI/UX, clear video, clean code

- **Innovation:** Novel approach or unique solution
- **Impact:** Solves a real problem

AI Tools Are Allowed

- Claude Code, Copilot, ChatGPT - all OK
- The judges care about the result, not how you typed it
- Vibe coding is totally acceptable

Your Tech Stack Advantages

You already have: - **Vertex AI** / **Gemini** - Google Cloud AI - **ADK** - Agent Development Kit - **Firebase** - Hosting, Functions, Firestore - **Resend** - Email API - **Puppeteer** / **PDF generation** - Document tools

Project Ideas: 1. DiagnosticPro - Already built, polish and submit 2. IntentMail MCP - AI email automation 3. New AI agent using ADK + Gemini 4. AI-powered document analyzer

Bounty Platforms (Alternative)

If hackathons aren't your thing:

Platform	Status	Notes
Algora	Active	\$100-500 bounties, competitive
Cal.com	Active	\$20-500, heavily contested
Opire	Active	Few small bounties
Gitcoin	Pivoted to hackathons	
Bountysource	Dead (bankrupt)	

Action Plan

1. **Now:** Pick hackathon (recommend AI Vibe)
2. **This week:** Plan project, form team if needed
3. **Jan 30:** Start building
4. **Feb 2:** Submit before deadline
5. **Feb TBD:** Win prizes!

Generated by Claude Code - January 10, 2026